British, and especially the once-masterful Macnaghten, have behaved so idiotically? ‘Sir William Macnaghten did not listen to me,’ a despairing Shuja wrote to Auckland, saying how over and again he had explained to the Envoy that:

> unless by slaying or enchaining these people nothing is to be done; I know them well; but my speaking was useless . . .
>
> Often I said I would leave the country as there would certainly be an insurrection; but the envoy told me to be comforted and that he would settle the country with a few regiments. Again I said, ‘beware you are deceived; I will withdraw from the land,’ but I was tied down by my family, the winter came and I did not go; and then the affair came to a head. What dogs are these people! I had hoped to have settled all the country between Khorasan and Persia; who were the men to oppose me? But they made it an affair between Kafirs and Islam; on which account all the people turned from me.[15]

Particularly galling for Shuja was the way Macnaghten in his final negotiations had handed over such huge sums to Akbar Khan after so long trimming Shuja’s own budget, thus leaving him without any resources to mount a proper defence:

> Mahomed Akbar and others were dying of hunger – you by your money have set them on foot. You gave money to your enemy, you armed him to slay yourself; what he is doing is with your money; but for it he could not have maintained himself for ten days.
>
> I did not even drink water without Sir William Macnaghten’s sanction and often I said to him: we will be wrecked. Captain Lawrence is alive, before him I often said this. Captain Burnes is now dead, he followed his own heart, and he was deceived by men’s words. I told him men are dissatisfied with you and intend you evil, do not be deceived; but it was of no use . . . Until now by one device or another I have carried on, but now they send men to me and say that the Shah is sinking Islam, men say that I am with you [British] and on this account they have left me.

He ended, characteristically: ‘Whatever may be the will of God, that will happen.’[16]

As George Lawrence was the one officer left alive with whom Shuja still had a close relationship, it was to him that Shuja sent a last urgent message begging him once more to warn the General not to leave the cantonment, and emphasising that no trust whatsoever could be placed in the promises of Akbar Khan. ‘As long as we held our position, the king urged, they could not hurt us; but if we once abandoned it we were dead men,’ wrote Lawrence. ‘Of these warnings I duly informed Pottinger, who took me to